Income inequality in Latin America
What changed in the 2026 update

Country comparisons and explanations
Pretax national income, shared equally between adults in a couple

Brazil's newly supplied research series is on hold for scientific review. The current release uses the project's existing Brazilian estimates. Ecuador's supplied historical series remains included.

How to read the comparisons

The figures compare the November 2025 release, the earlier 2026 estimate exported on 22 October, and the current estimate. They show the share of national income received by the richest 10%, 1% and 0.1%. Lines that overlap indicate little or no change between those versions.

A change from 20% to 22% is an increase of 2 percentage points. The 2025 endpoint generally carries the last available distribution forward; it is not a new survey observation. The country notes identify other interpolated or carried years.

Main findings

- New surveys extend coverage to 2024. Historical revisions supplied by the survey provider can also alter earlier estimates.

- Argentina's largest changes mainly enter before the final distribution fit. Costa Rica corrects an ineffective adjustment for the very highest incomes.

- Peru restores two tax-reference years and uses updated annual accounts. Colombia and Ecuador now incorporate their accepted 2024 accounts.

- Brazil's proposed supplied replacement is excluded pending review. Ecuador retains its supplied 1990-2022 history and extends it using changes in four broad income groups.

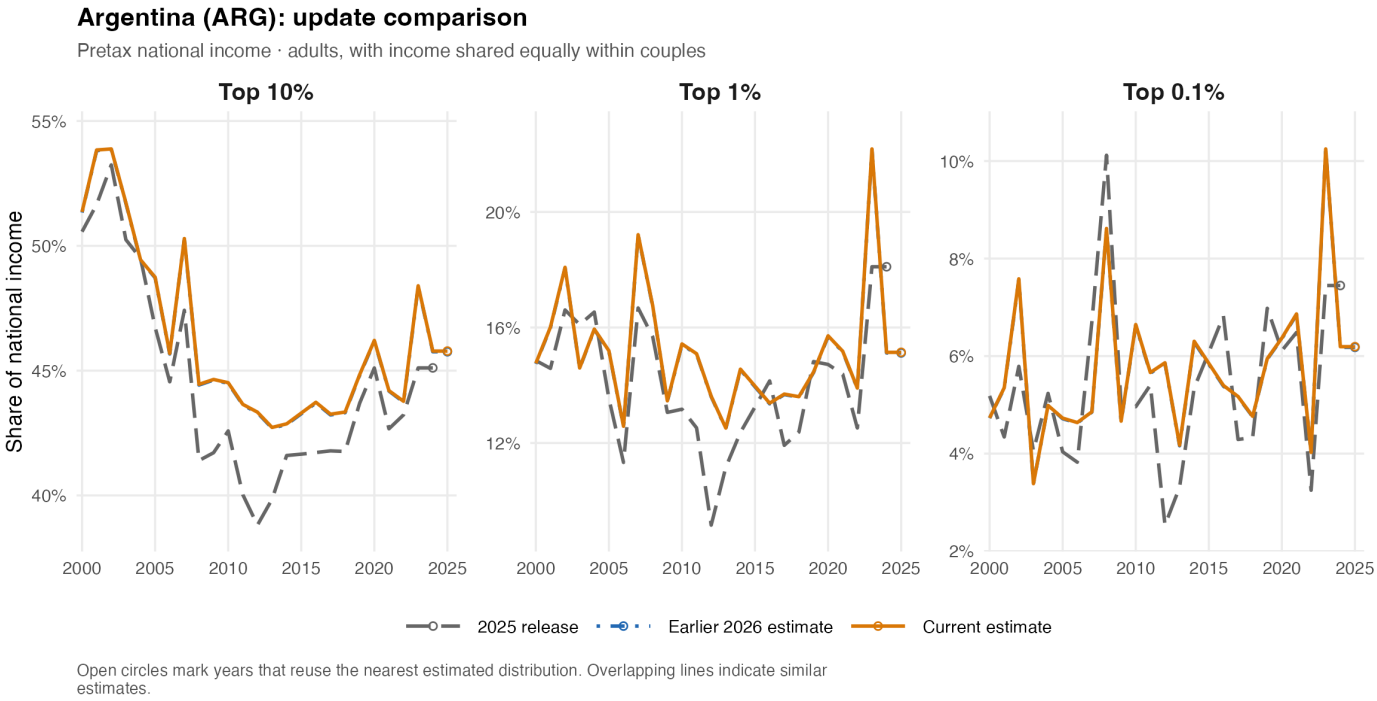
- Common checks now make bottom- and middle-income summaries agree with the detailed distribution. Monetary amounts use the current World Inequality Database benchmark.

Largest common-year differences from the 2025 delivery

Country	Top 10%: largest gap	Top 1%: largest gap
Argentina	4.53 pp (2012)	4.46 pp (2012)
Brazil	0.90 pp (2002)	1.29 pp (2021)
Chile	0.98 pp (2009)	1.91 pp (2009)
Colombia	3.72 pp (2024)	6.46 pp (2024)
Costa Rica	3.18 pp (2018)	4.62 pp (2018)
Dominican Republic	2.95 pp (2024)	3.86 pp (2024)
Ecuador	12.52 pp (2016)	9.93 pp (2006)
Mexico	1.35 pp (2024)	0.88 pp (2020)
Peru	2.55 pp (2021)	3.52 pp (2007)
El Salvador	1.81 pp (2005)	5.37 pp (2000)
Uruguay	1.53 pp (2022)	4.55 pp (2024)

Each entry is the largest difference, in either direction, across years available in both releases. It measures the size of the revision; it does not identify its cause.

Argentina



Argentina differs from last year largely because the income data entering the final calculation changed. The earlier decision to apply a common survey correction to every year from 2000 through 2014 remains in place; it was also used in the 2025 release.

What changed

- The correction comes from comparisons of Argentine surveys with Argentine tax records. It transfers the typical correction at each income rank across years; it does not import another country's income distribution.

- The survey provider revised historical data. For example, the 2012 sample increased from 54,589 to 110,850 observations because it now includes the third and fourth quarters, rather than only the fourth. Some 2007 income values and classifications also changed.

- A controlled comparison for 2012 attributes 3.93 percentage points of the higher top-1% share to changes in the income data already prepared for calculation, and 0.53 points to the final distribution-fitting method. The first component includes survey revisions and prior income adjustments.

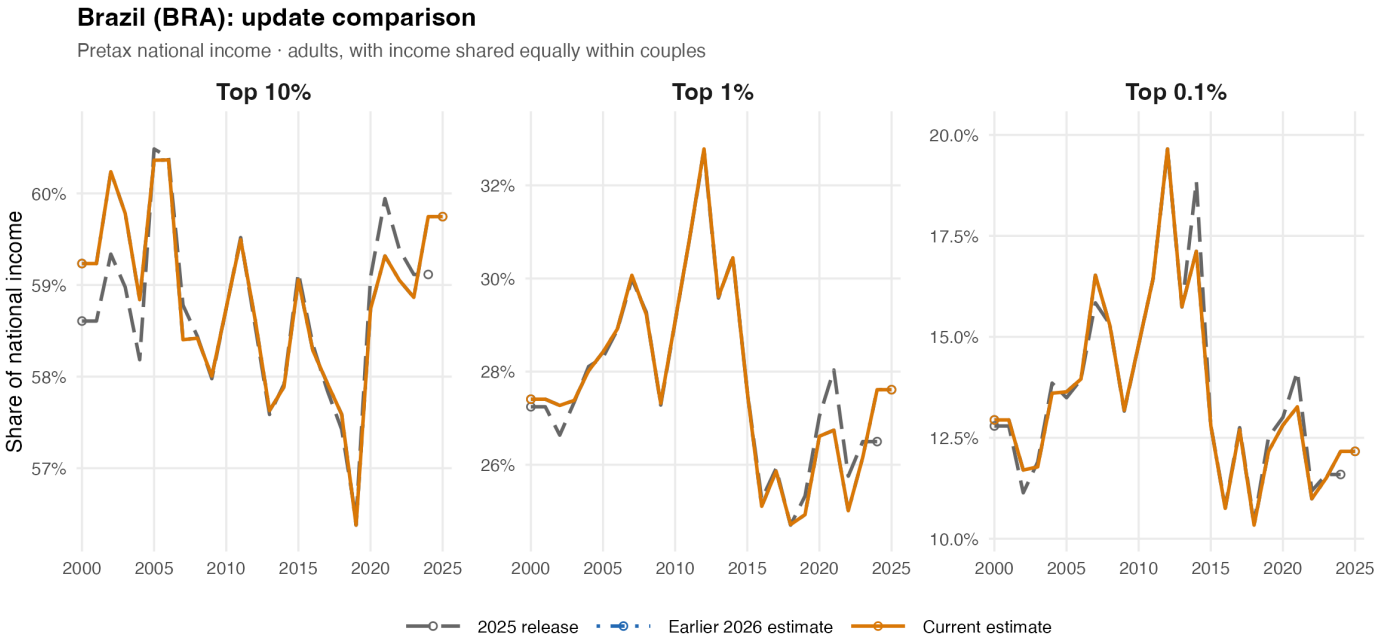
- Later updates to national accounts in other countries also changed the information used to estimate missing Argentine income components. These final revisions are much smaller than the earlier historical gap.

Share / comparison	Last year in both	Change that year	Largest gap
Top 10% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.03 pp	0.03 pp (2022)
Top 1% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.02 pp	0.03 pp (2002)
Top 10% vs 2025 release	2024	0.67 pp	4.53 pp (2012)
Top 1% vs 2025 release	2024	-2.96 pp	4.46 pp (2012)

What we can conclude

The evidence shows that changes in the data before final fitting dominate the gap in most years. It does not establish how much of that component comes from survey revisions alone, as opposed to the adjustments that reconcile survey income with national income.

Brazil



Brazil continues to use the project's estimates based on household surveys, tax records and national accounts. The separate series supplied by Morgan and Souza is on hold while its scientific interpretation is reviewed; it is not used in the current publication or in regional estimates.

What changed

- The update adds the 2024 household survey and tax information for that year.

- The survey provider revised the population weights for 2016-2023. Those revisions can change historical income shares even when the people recorded in the survey are unchanged.

- The detailed national-account inputs used to divide income into its components still end in 2021. The overall national-income benchmark is updated separately, using the same World Inequality Database source as for other countries.

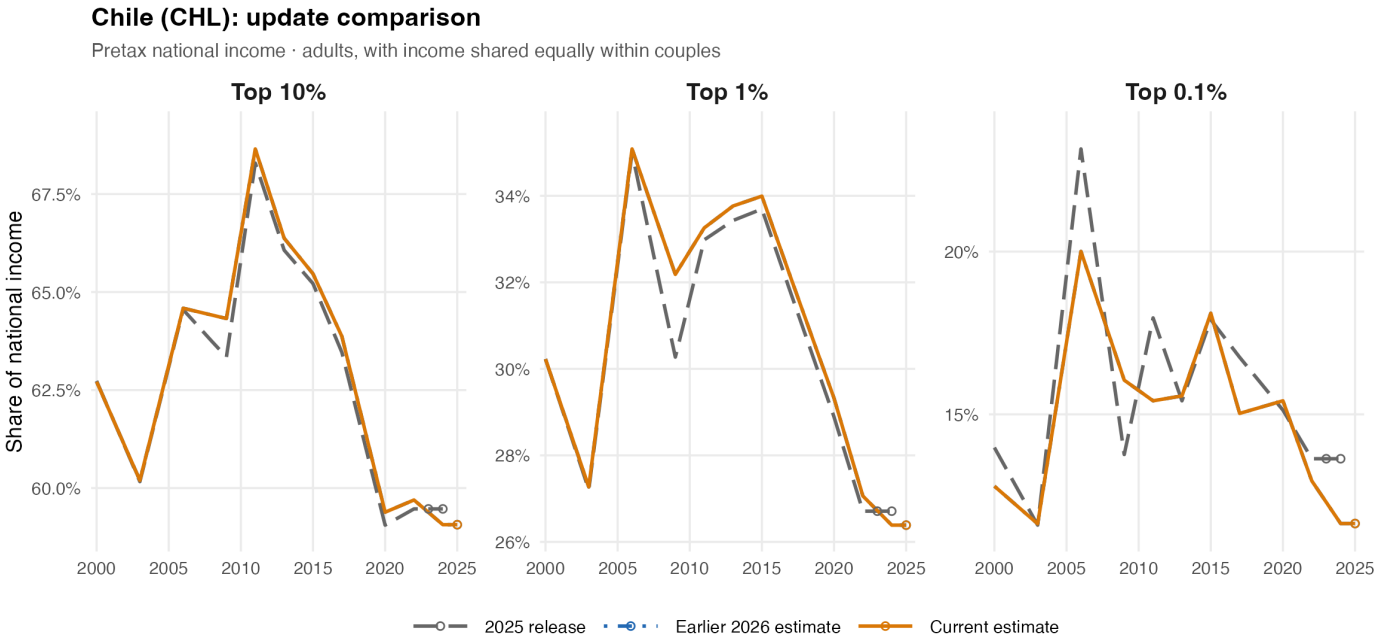
- The supplied Morgan and Souza file and its review materials are retained for further study. Its earlier historical observations and proposed continuation are excluded from this release.

Share / comparison	Last year in both	Change that year	Largest gap
Top 10% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.00 pp	0.00 pp (unchanged)
Top 1% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.00 pp	0.00 pp (unchanged)
Top 10% vs 2025 release	2024	0.63 pp	0.90 pp (2002)
Top 1% vs 2025 release	2024	1.11 pp	1.29 pp (2021)

What we can conclude

The differences shown here concern the existing survey-and-tax method, not the proposed supplied replacement. The individual effects of survey weights, tax corrections and other income adjustments have not been fully separated.

Chile



Chile has new survey and tax information for 2024, alongside revised national accounts. The update therefore includes both a new year and revisions to some earlier estimates.

What changed

- The 2024 survey is corrected using tax information from the same year. Surveys are conducted periodically; estimates between survey years do not represent additional surveys.

- The national-account review identified 362 revised values and 88 additions, extending the available data to 2024.

- Updates elsewhere in the region also affected some income components that Chile estimates using information from other countries.

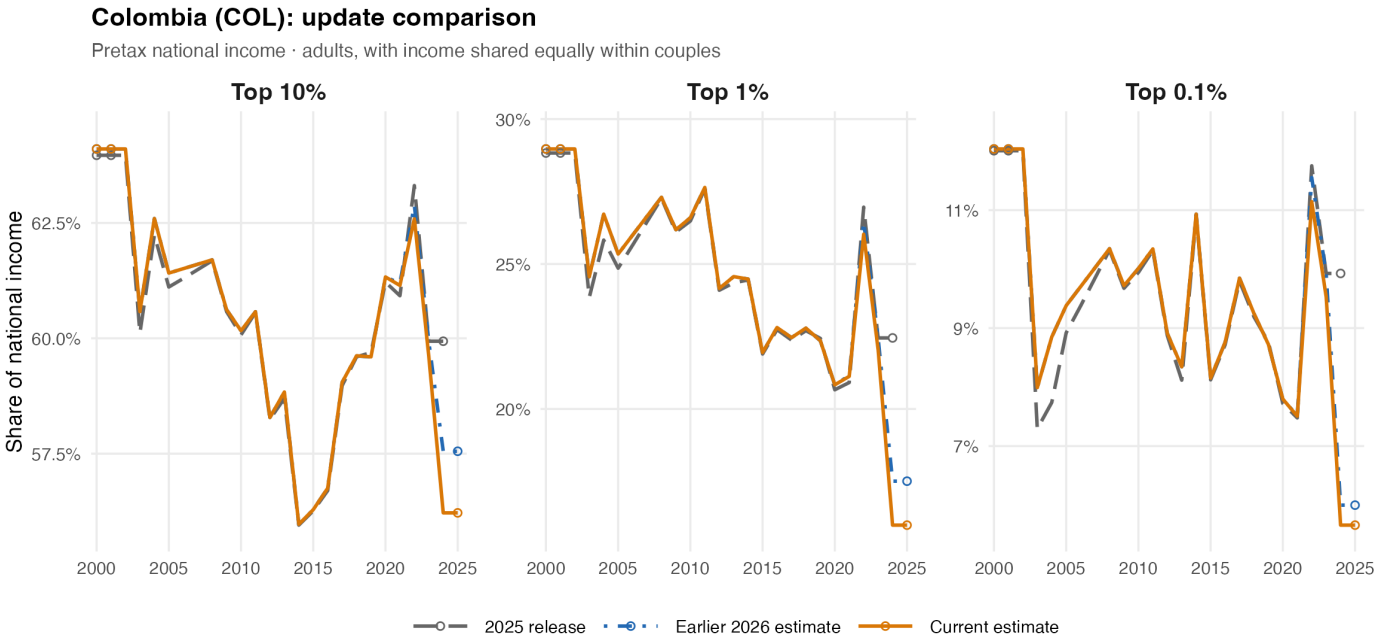
- A rounding problem in a very small 2024 income group was fixed. This allowed the calculation to finish without changing the income totals or the top shares used to determine the distribution.

Share / comparison	Last year in both	Change that year	Largest gap
Top 10% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.00 pp	0.00 pp (2003)
Top 1% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.00 pp	0.00 pp (2003)
Top 10% vs 2025 release	2024	-0.40 pp	0.98 pp (2009)
Top 1% vs 2025 release	2024	-0.32 pp	1.91 pp (2009)

What we can conclude

The total differences are measured in the figure and table. We have not separately quantified the contribution of each new survey, tax and national-account input. The final rounding fix does not explain the gap from the 2025 release.

Colombia



Colombia now uses the accepted 2024 national accounts and their historical revisions, which the earlier 2026 calculation had overlooked. The 2024 survey is available, but tax information ends in 2023, so the correction for missing high incomes in 2024 still relies on other Colombian years.

What changed

- The tax evidence used to estimate survey corrections covers 2014-2023. No new 2024 tax observation is assumed.

- The accepted national accounts contain 86 revised values and 49 additions. The final calculation now uses them.

- These accounts substantially change the amounts of wage and capital income allocated across households. For example, the estimate of profits retained by companies rises from 2.54% to 4.77% of national income in 2024.

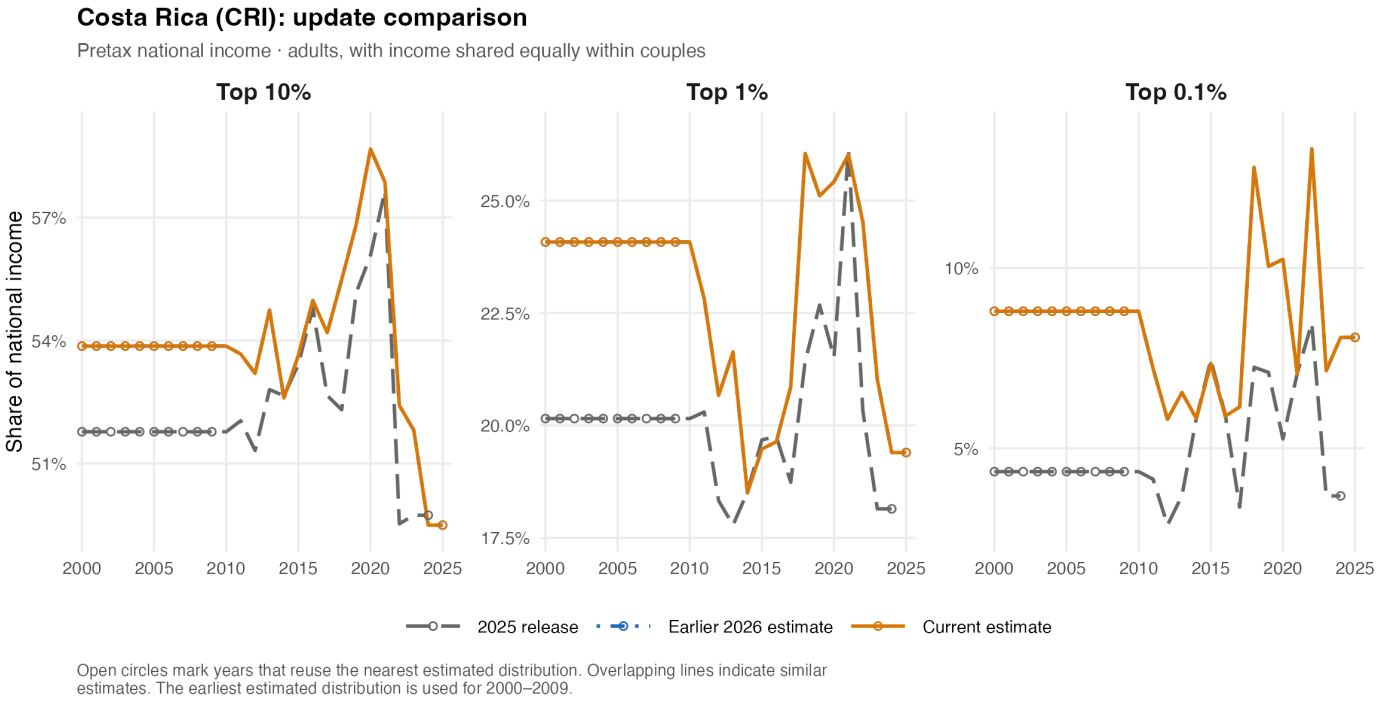
- Compared with the earlier 2026 estimate, the final 2024 top-10% share falls by 1.34 percentage points. This is the net result of the revised income components, not the change in any one adjustment factor.

Share / comparison	Last year in both	Change that year	Largest gap
Top 10% vs earlier 2026	2025	-1.34 pp	1.34 pp (2024)
Top 1% vs earlier 2026	2025	-1.52 pp	1.52 pp (2024)
Top 10% vs 2025 release	2024	-3.72 pp	3.72 pp (2024)
Top 1% vs 2025 release	2024	-6.46 pp	6.46 pp (2024)

What we can conclude

The new 2024 survey and national accounts should not be described as a new 2024 tax-based observation. Historical survey weights and some survey records also changed, so earlier-year differences need not be caused solely by the accounts.

Costa Rica



Costa Rica adds the 2024 survey. Its detailed national-account inputs are unchanged. An important methodological correction now applies the previously intended adjustment to the very highest incomes, explaining why the series can change even without new tax data.

What changed

- Tax-and-survey comparisons from 2010-2016 remain the basis for the correction. A typical correction across those years is applied consistently, including to the agreed replacement estimates for 2010-2016.

- The adjustment for the top 0.01% had not been taking effect because of an implementation error. It now does. The established factors of 2.18 for the top 0.1% and 7.23 for the top 0.01%, with their existing exceptions in 2016 and 2021, are retained.

- The distribution-fitting method now preserves the retained income totals rather than reducing inconsistent group means. This matters especially at the very top.

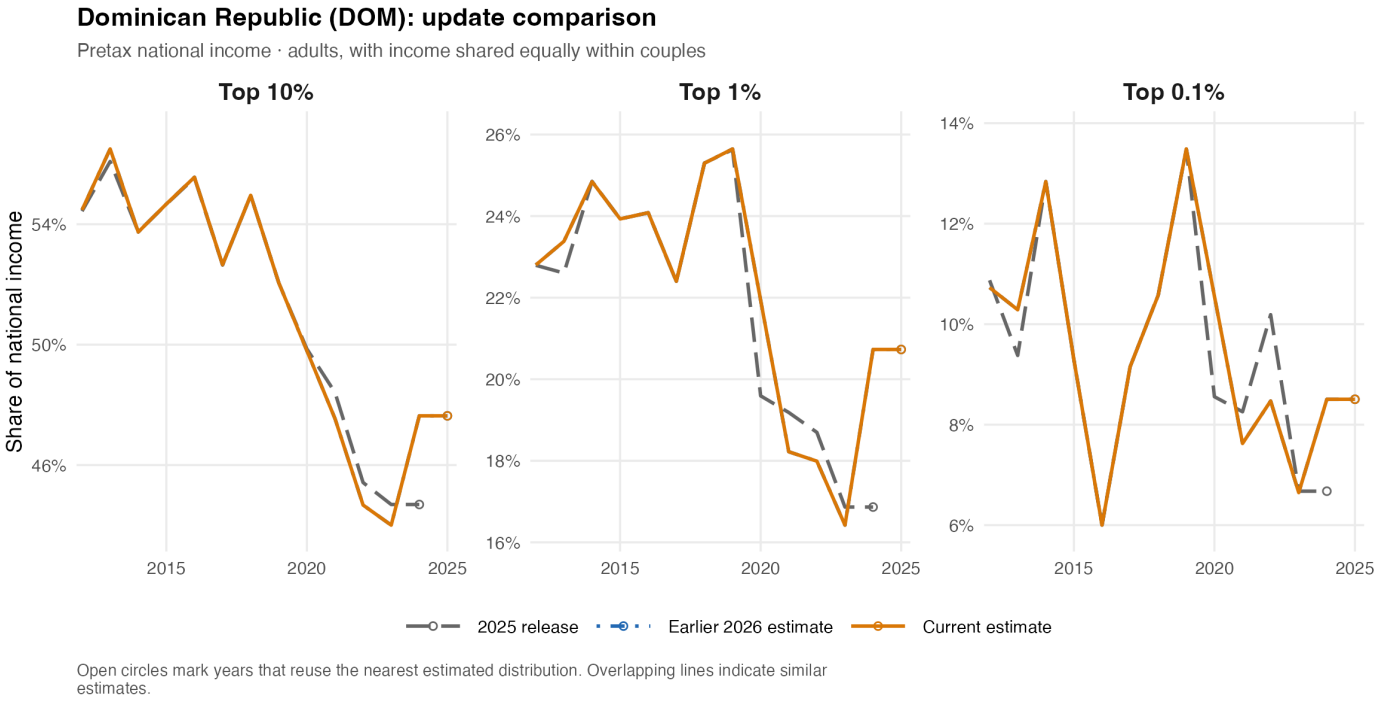
- The pre-2010 series still uses the 2010 distribution. As a result, revisions to 2010 also revise the backward estimates for 2000-2009.

Share / comparison	Last year in both	Change that year	Largest gap
Top 10% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.00 pp	0.00 pp (unchanged)
Top 1% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.00 pp	0.00 pp (unchanged)
Top 10% vs 2025 release	2024	-0.24 pp	3.18 pp (2018)
Top 1% vs 2025 release	2024	1.25 pp	4.62 pp (2018)

What we can conclude

The backward series does not contain independent evidence of annual changes before 2010. The new result reflects a corrected calculation of the intended method; it is not evidence of revised national accounts for those years.

Dominican Republic



The Dominican Republic adds the 2024 survey but no new year of tax data. A historical national-account source had been omitted from the calculation. Restoring it corrected an excessive allocation of capital income and brought the series closer to the previous release.

What changed

- The restored source is the same historical file used previously, rather than a new national-account revision.

- Its information on the composition of income in 2014-2016 reduces the later capital-income adjustment factor from 42.82 to 25.50, close to the historical comparator of 25.68.

- The correction based on tax records continues to use 2012-2019. The 2020 case remains excluded.

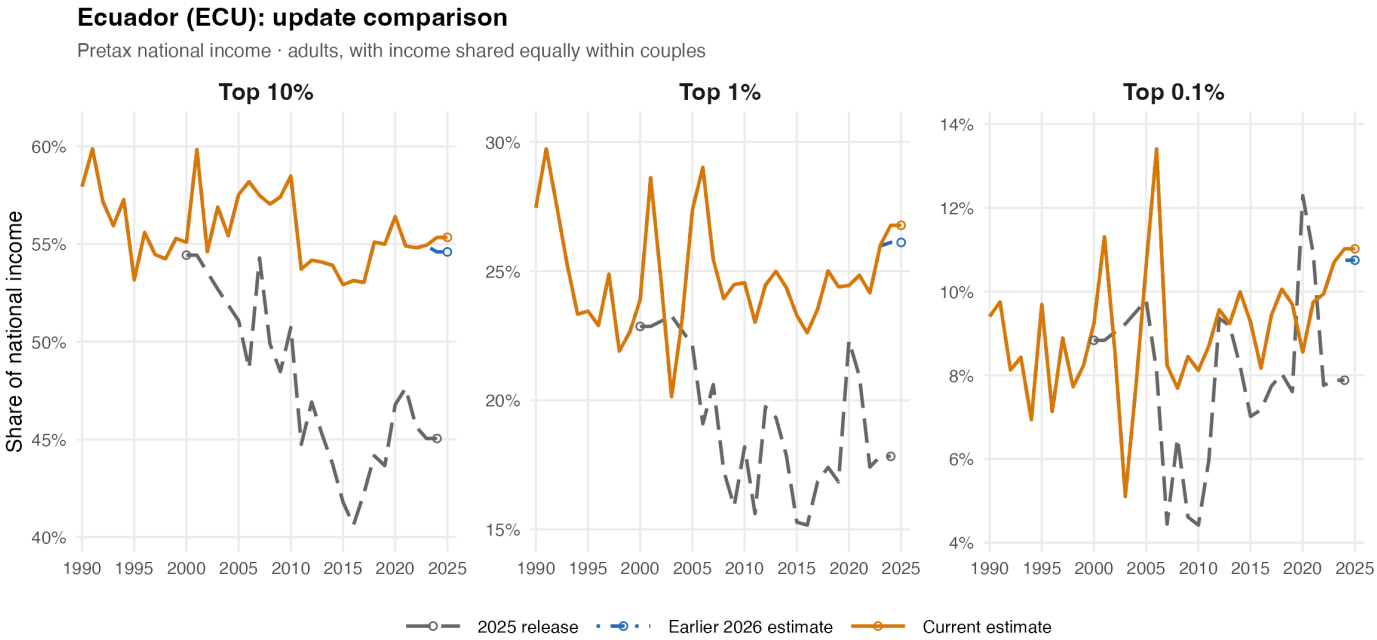
- The publication continues to begin in 2012. Earlier calculations are retained for internal use, but are not added to the published series.

Share / comparison	Last year in both	Change that year	Largest gap
Top 10% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.00 pp	0.00 pp (unchanged)
Top 1% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.00 pp	0.00 pp (unchanged)
Top 10% vs 2025 release	2024	2.95 pp	2.95 pp (2024)
Top 1% vs 2025 release	2024	3.86 pp	3.86 pp (2024)

What we can conclude

Restoring the missing source explains an identified distortion, but the factor change is not itself a change in a top income share. The final differences also include survey and other updates.

Ecuador



Ecuador uses the distribution supplied by Markus Nabernegg for 1990-2022. The project extends it to 2023-2024 using changes in its own Ecuador estimates. Monetary income levels use the same World Inequality Database benchmark as for all other countries.

What changed

- The supplied series is attributed to Nabernegg, M. (2026), Extreme Income Inequality in Ecuador-Dollarization, Commodity Price Boom, and Citizen Revolution. The original file is retained separately from the prepared series.

- Preparation reconciles small numerical inconsistencies and places the data on the common population grid. The accepted historical distribution is retained through 2022.

- After 2022, the continuation follows changes in four groups: the bottom 50%, middle 40%, next 9% and top 1%. The changes come from Ecuador's own survey-based estimates, using 2022 as the common starting point.

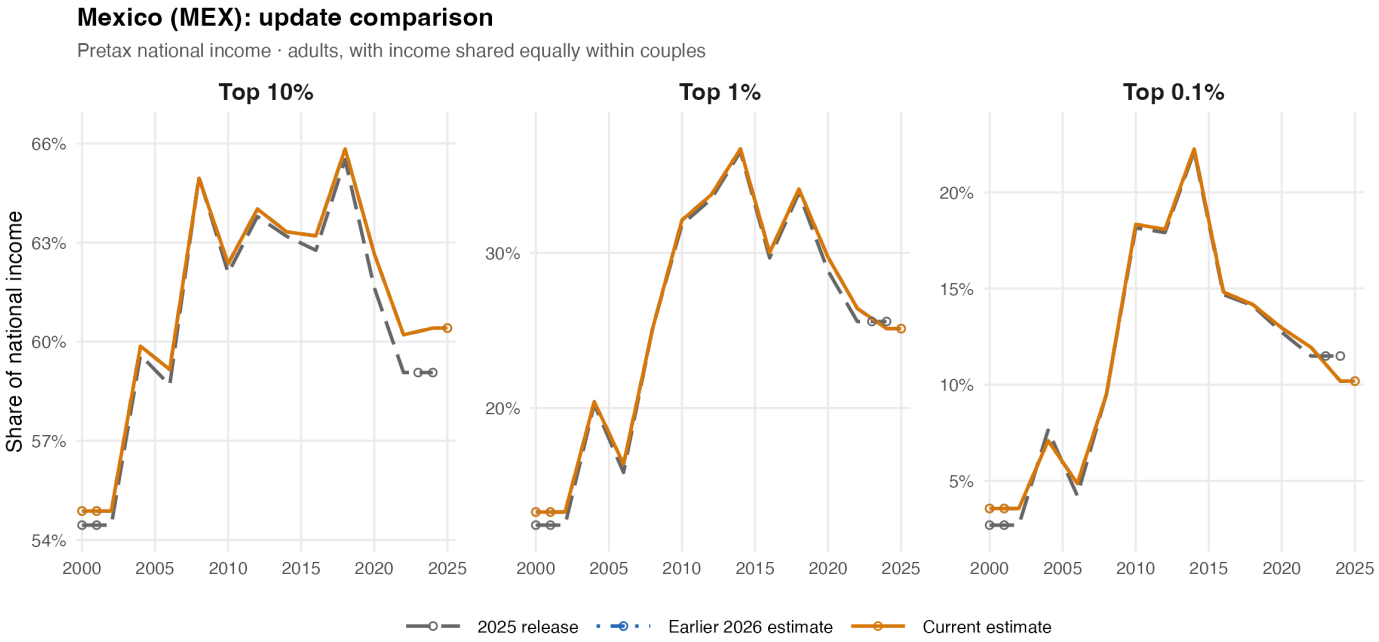
- The continuation now incorporates the accepted 2024 national accounts and revised 2023 values. The 2024 top-10% share is 0.74 percentage points above the earlier 2026 estimate. For 2025, the 2024 distribution is carried forward.

Share / comparison	Last year in both	Change that year	Largest gap
Top 10% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.74 pp	0.74 pp (2024)
Top 1% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.66 pp	0.66 pp (2024)
Top 10% vs 2025 release	2024	10.29 pp	12.52 pp (2016)
Top 1% vs 2025 release	2024	8.94 pp	9.93 pp (2006)

What we can conclude

Some population and currency definitions in the supplied source still require confirmation. Published monetary amounts use the common external benchmark; they are not copied from the supplier. The continuation is our estimate and is attributed separately from the supplied years.

Mexico



Mexico adds the 2024 survey and updated national accounts. Its historical tax-based wage distributions are reused because the underlying information has not changed. The combination can still produce revised estimates even though the tax inputs are the same.

What changed

- Household surveys cover even years from 2000 through 2024. Estimates for intervening years do not represent new surveys.

- The national-account update extends coverage to 2024 and includes 65 revised values and 49 additions.

- The tax-based wage distributions are retained from the earlier work. They do not need to be recalculated from the large original datasets.

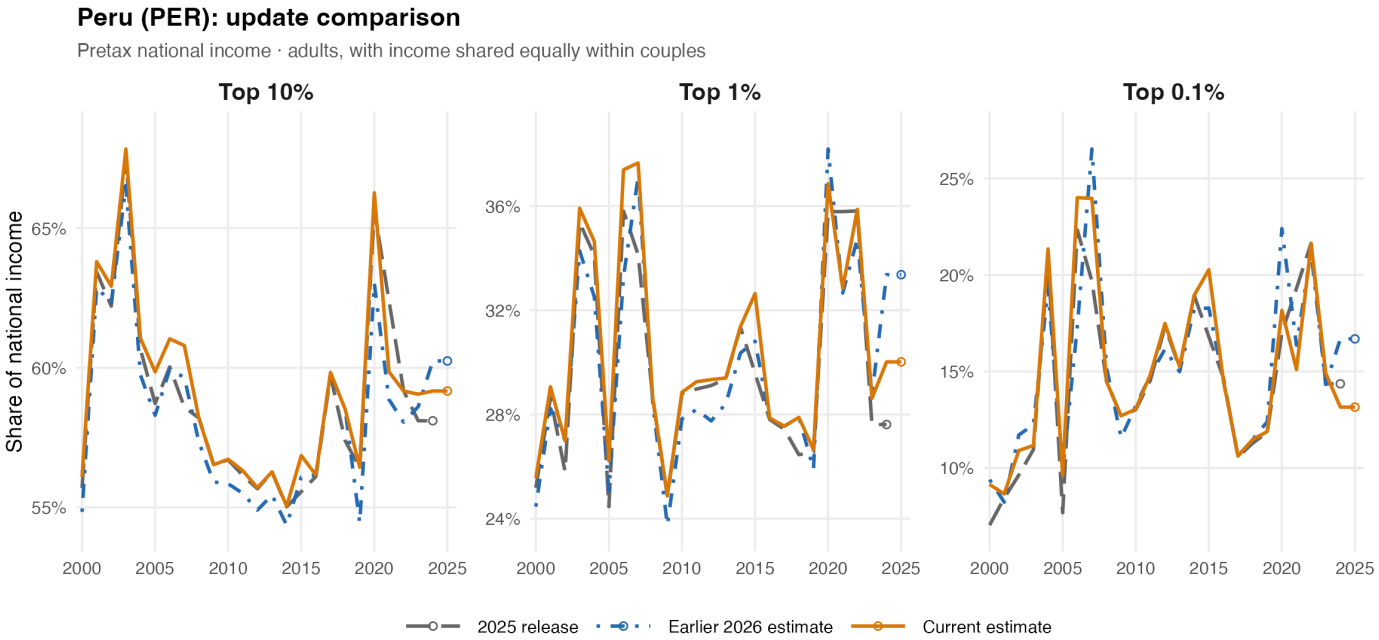
- The correction uses the years with matching survey and tax evidence: 2010, 2012 and 2014.

Share / comparison	Last year in both	Change that year	Largest gap
Top 10% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.00 pp	0.00 pp (unchanged)
Top 1% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.00 pp	0.00 pp (unchanged)
Top 10% vs 2025 release	2024	1.35 pp	1.35 pp (2024)
Top 1% vs 2025 release	2024	-0.46 pp	0.88 pp (2020)

What we can conclude

No full calculation has separated the influence of each input on the differences from the 2025 release. Reusing tax data does not imply that the survey or national-income components are unchanged.

Peru



Peru again uses tax information from 2019 and 2020, alongside 2016-2018. Those two years were used in the 2025 release but had initially been omitted from this update. The final series also incorporates revised annual national accounts and calculates two years that previously relied on interpolation.

What changed

- The historical tax inputs for 2019-2020 were recovered and the corrections recalculated. The comparison years are therefore again 2016-2020.

- Annual national accounts for 2007-2024 replace an outdated combined source. They include historical revisions as well as the new year.

- The estimates for 2015 and 2021 are now calculated directly from the available information. The 2021 top-10% share is 59.86%, compared with the previously interpolated 62.41%.

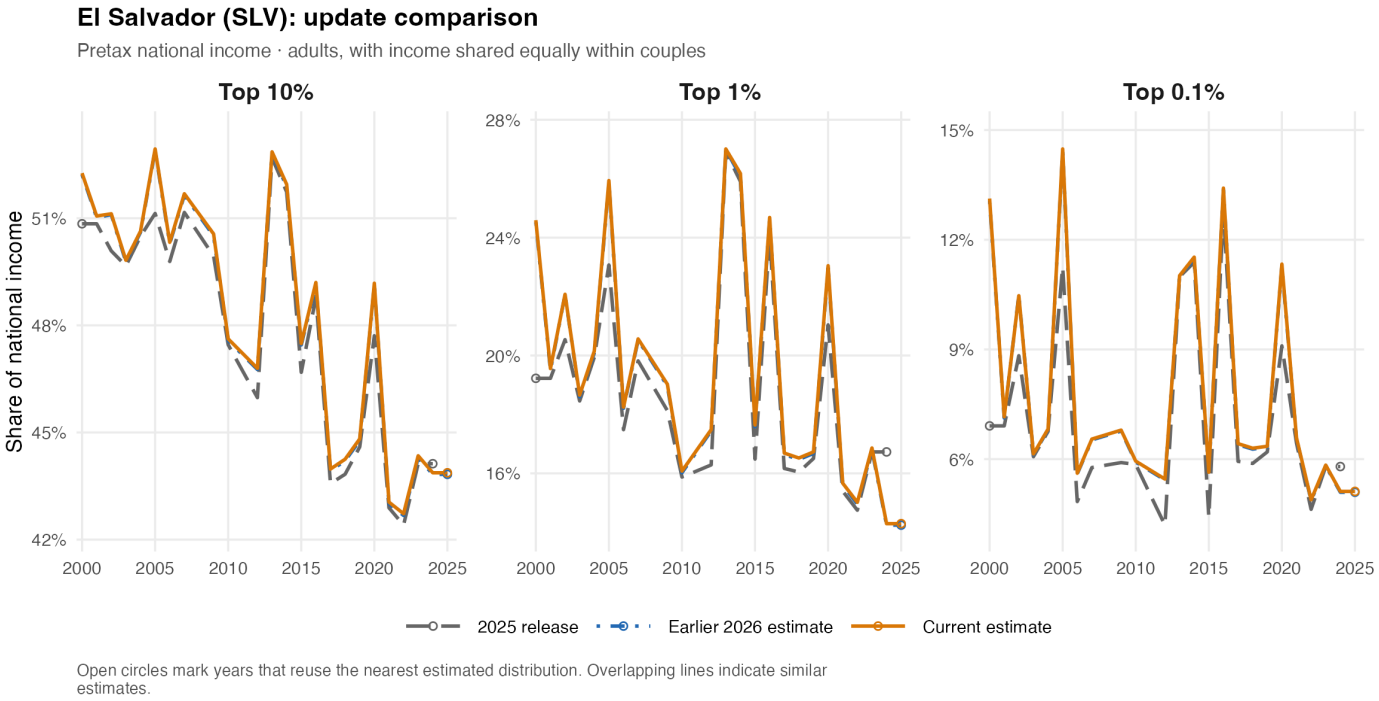
- Final top-10% shares for 2019 and 2020 are 56.44% and 66.26%, compared with 56.41% and 65.65% in the 2025 release. A separate precision repair prevents a tiny rounding discrepancy from discarding important information at the top.

Share / comparison	Last year in both	Change that year	Largest gap
Top 10% vs earlier 2026	2025	-1.08 pp	3.24 pp (2020)
Top 1% vs earlier 2026	2025	-3.35 pp	4.10 pp (2006)
Top 10% vs 2025 release	2024	1.07 pp	2.55 pp (2021)
Top 1% vs 2025 release	2024	2.40 pp	3.52 pp (2007)

What we can conclude

The restored tax years, updated accounts and direct calculations all affect the result. Historical survey weights were also revised. The report does not assign the full difference to a single cause; the direct 2015 and 2021 estimates remain visible for scientific review.

El Salvador



El Salvador adds the 2024 survey while retaining its historical tax evidence. It also uses information from other countries to estimate income components missing from its national accounts, so the restoration and revision of those countries' data can change its results.

What changed

- The tax-and-survey comparisons remain 2001-2007, 2009-2010 and 2012-2017; no new tax year is claimed.

- The missing surveys in 2008 and 2011 continue to be handled through interpolation.

- The correction for 2000 now calculates successfully under the existing eligibility rules.

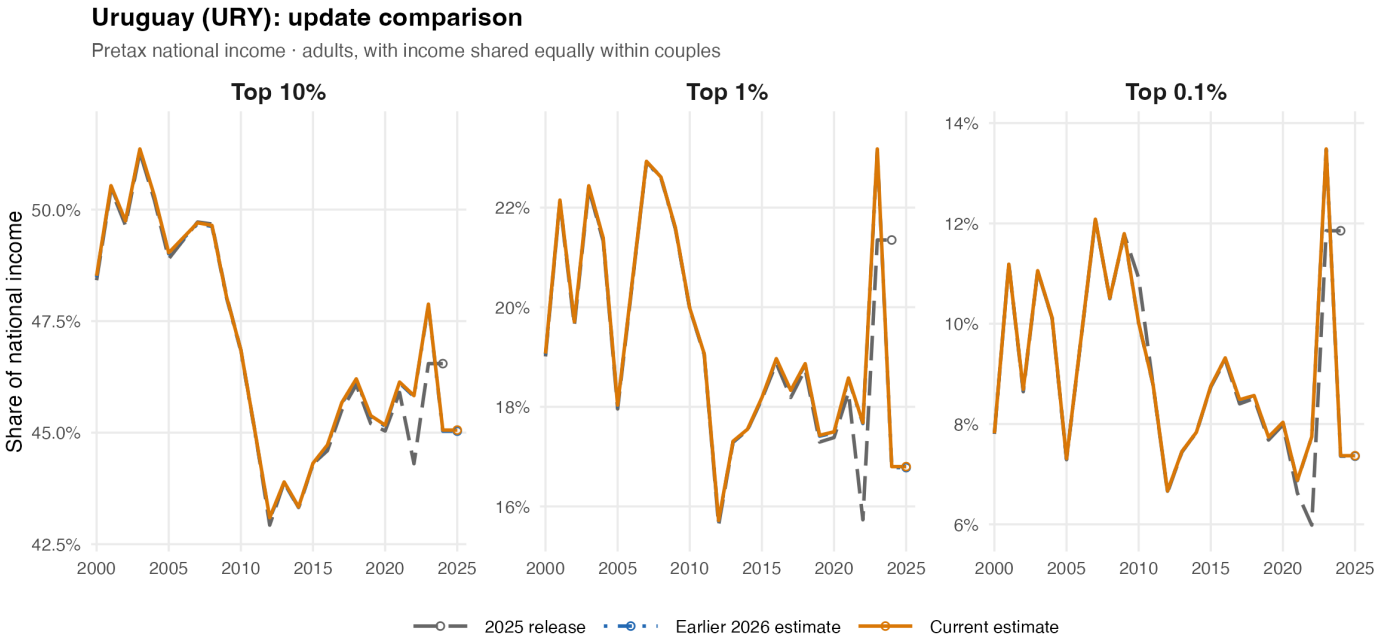
- Restored Dominican accounts and updated Peruvian, Colombian and Ecuadorian accounts were reflected in the information used to estimate missing income components. These updates have been carried through to the final results.

Share / comparison	Last year in both	Change that year	Largest gap
Top 10% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.04 pp	0.08 pp (2016)
Top 1% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.05 pp	0.10 pp (2014)
Top 10% vs 2025 release	2024	-0.25 pp	1.81 pp (2005)
Top 1% vs 2025 release	2024	-2.43 pp	5.37 pp (2000)

What we can conclude

No complete breakdown of the separate contributions to El Salvador's change has been produced. A change in a factor borrowed from other countries should not be interpreted as an equal change in an income share.

Uruguay



Uruguay adds the 2024 survey and further national-account information for 2022. Its historical tax distributions and effective tax rates remain unchanged. Updates in other countries affect some of Uruguay's estimated income components.

What changed

- The historical tax distributions and tax rates for 2009-2016 are reused. They were already calculated from the underlying detailed data.

- The missing 2006 survey continues to be handled through interpolation.

- The national-account review adds 16 values for 2022 while retaining 112 previously available values in the reviewed categories.

- The final estimates incorporate changes to information used to estimate missing income components following the Dominican, Peruvian, Colombian and Ecuadorian updates.

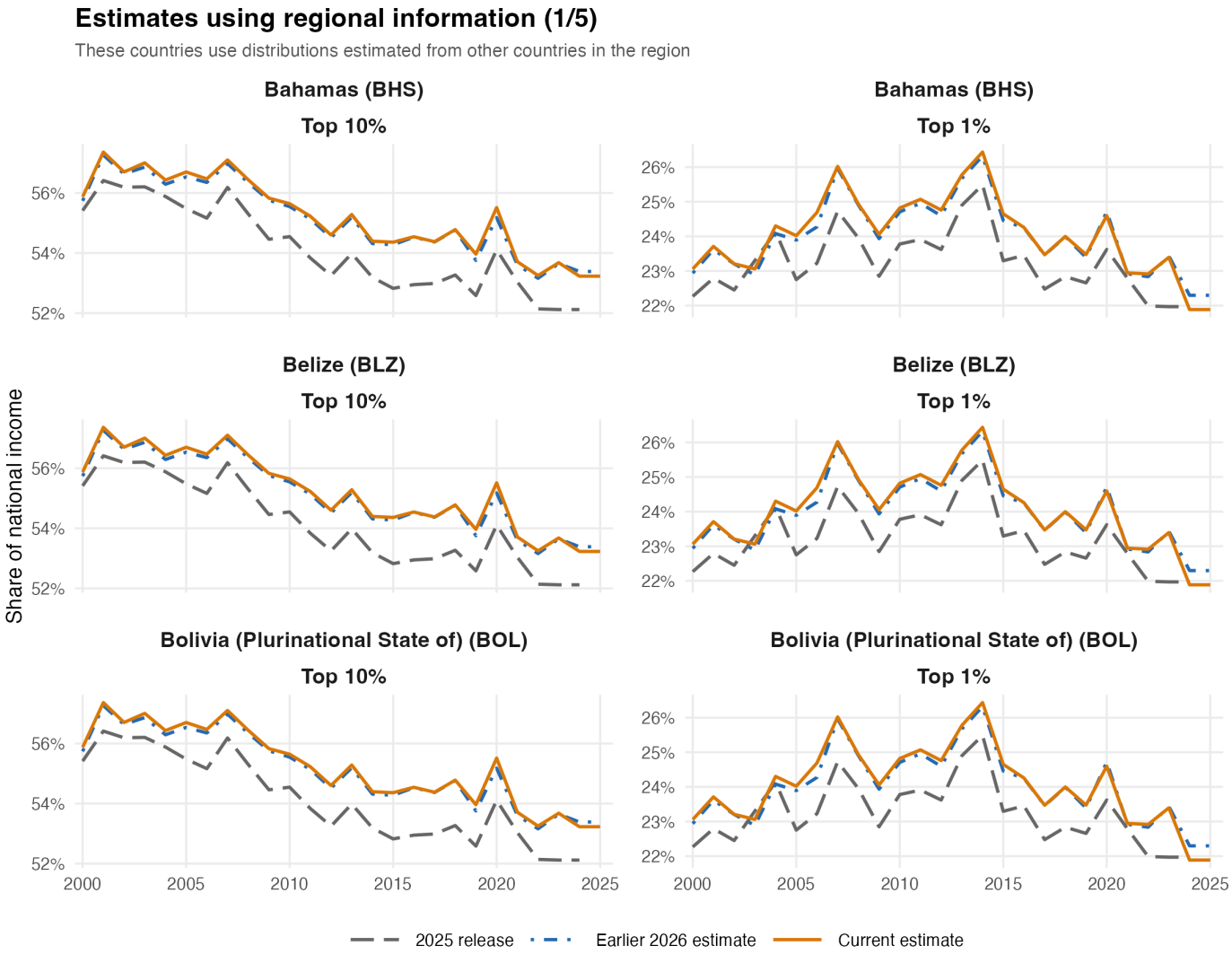
Share / comparison	Last year in both	Change that year	Largest gap
Top 10% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.02 pp	0.03 pp (2000)
Top 1% vs earlier 2026	2025	0.02 pp	0.02 pp (2023)
Top 10% vs 2025 release	2024	-1.49 pp	1.53 pp (2022)
Top 1% vs 2025 release	2024	-4.55 pp	4.55 pp (2024)

What we can conclude

The national-account categories have different year coverage; a first and last year do not imply complete annual information for every category. The total changes are measured here, but the effect of each input has not been fully separated.

Estimates based on regional evidence

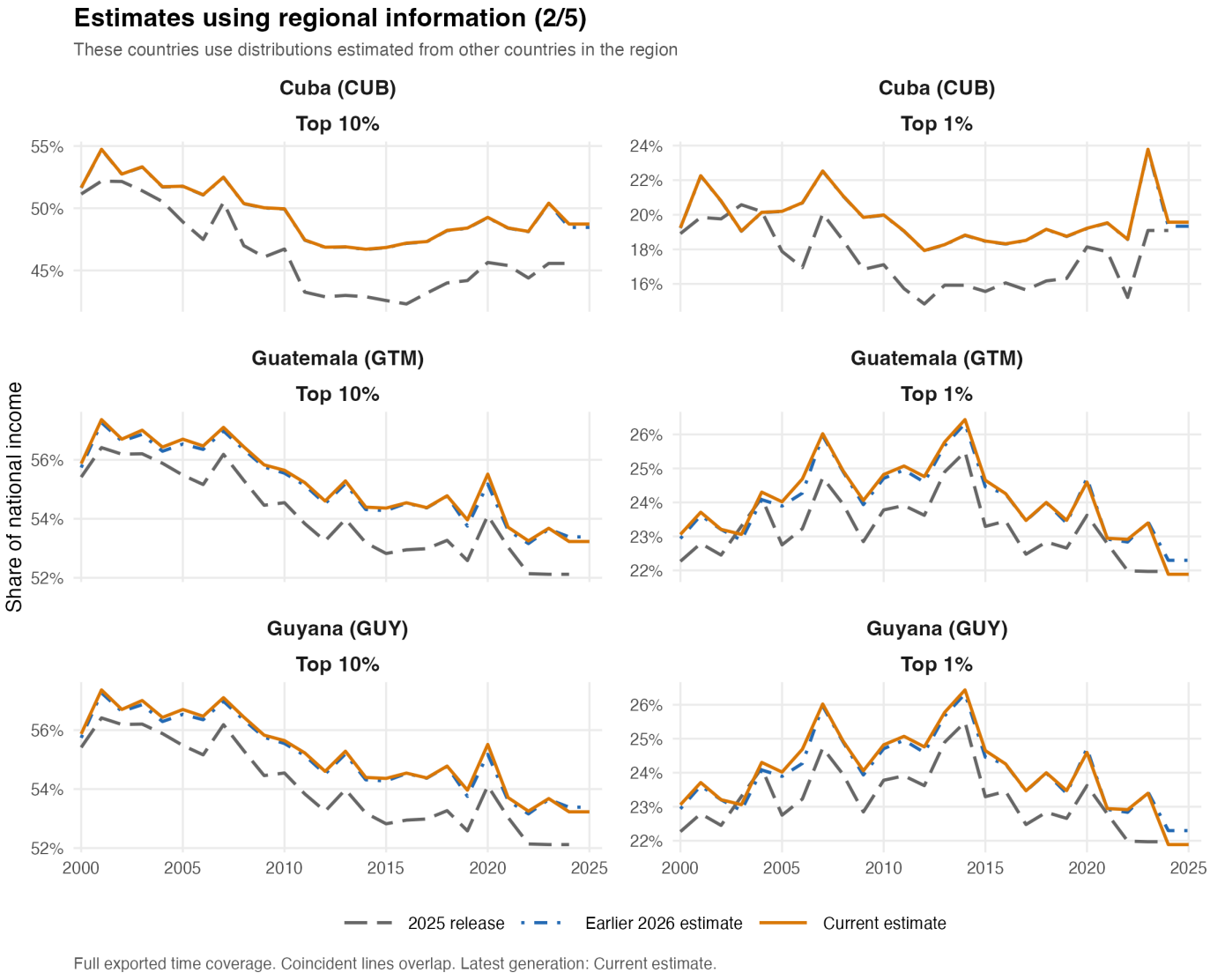
These countries use distributions estimated from other countries in the region. Similar curves reflect this shared method; they are not separate findings from local surveys.



These estimates are constructed from the available countries' distributions. They therefore change when those reference distributions change, even without new local surveys. The current calculation includes Ecuador's approved series and Brazil's existing survey-and-tax estimates; Brazil's proposed supplied replacement is excluded. Cuba uses a separate combination of Argentina, Ecuador and Uruguay.

Estimates based on regional evidence | continued

These countries use distributions estimated from other countries in the region. Similar curves reflect this shared method; they are not separate findings from local surveys.

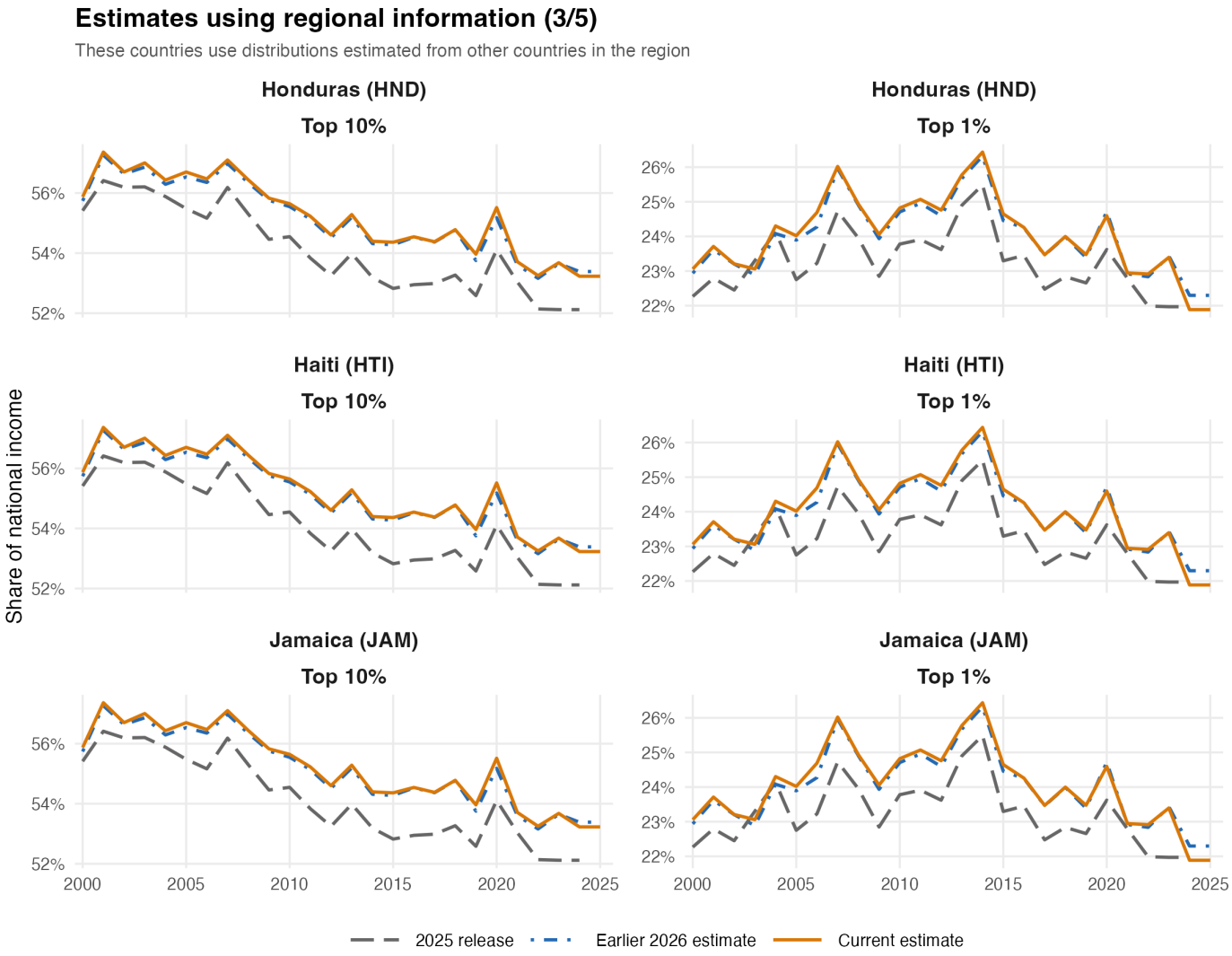


Full exported time coverage. Coincident lines overlap. Latest generation: Current estimate.

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Estimates based on regional evidence | continued

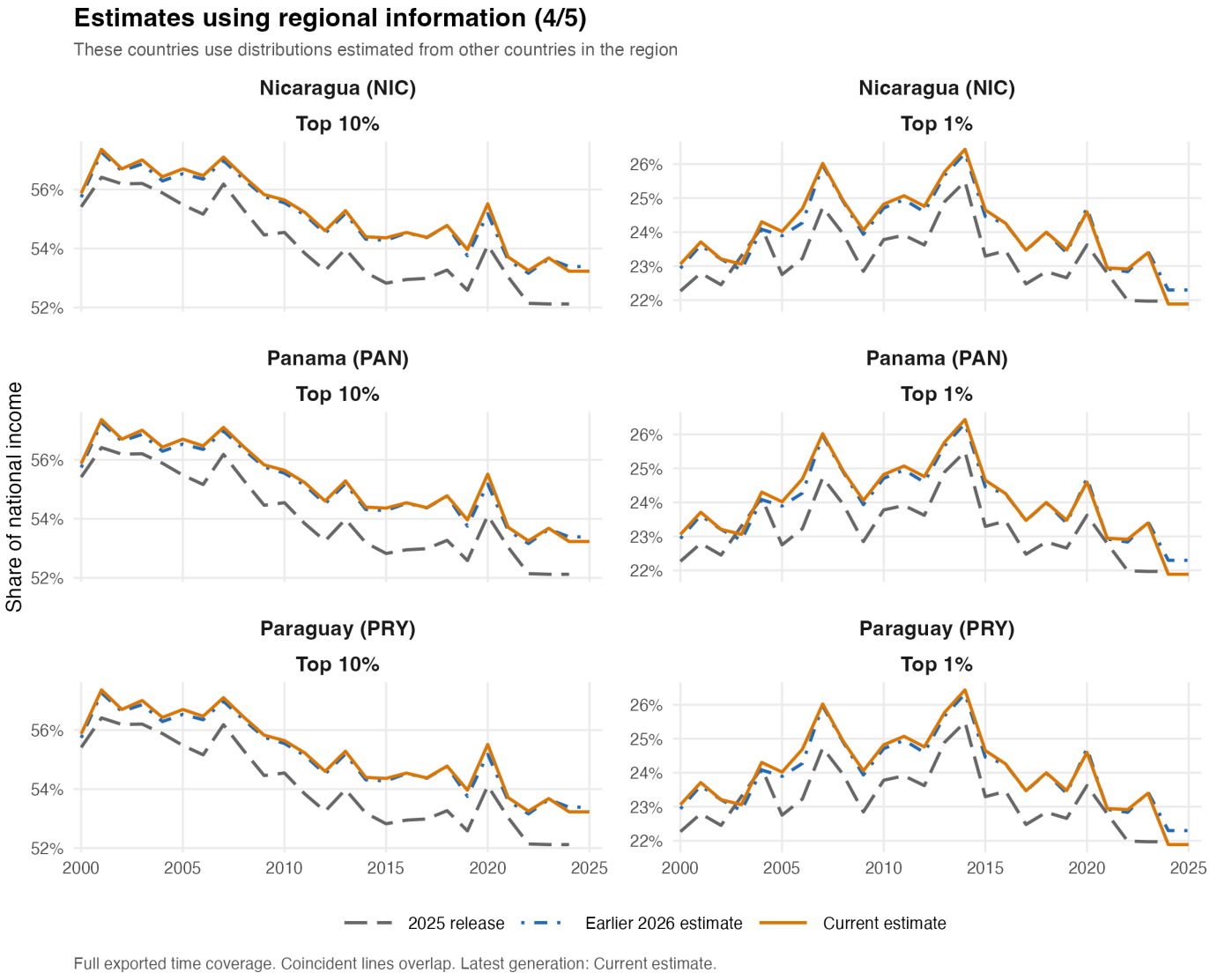
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Estimates based on regional evidence | continued

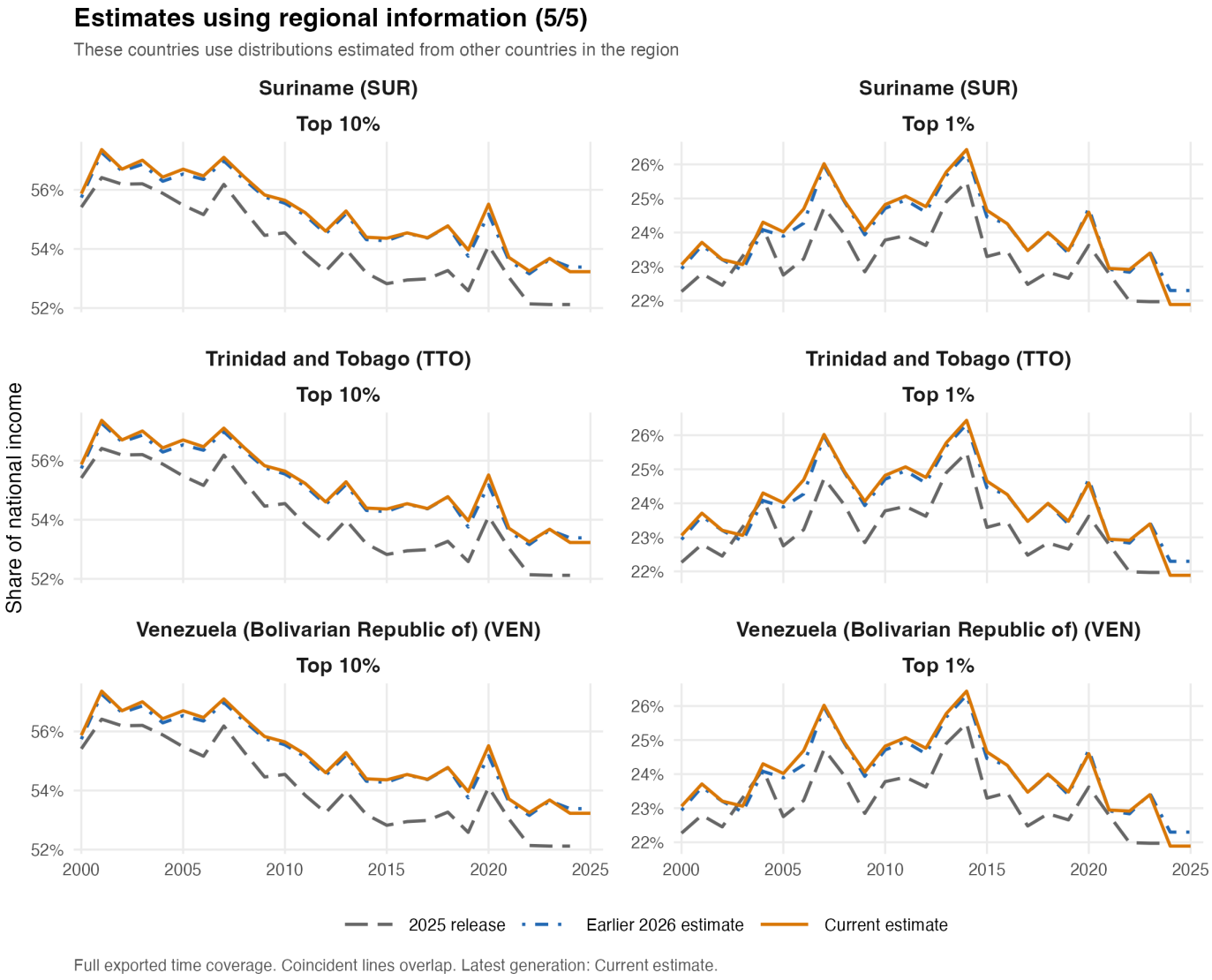
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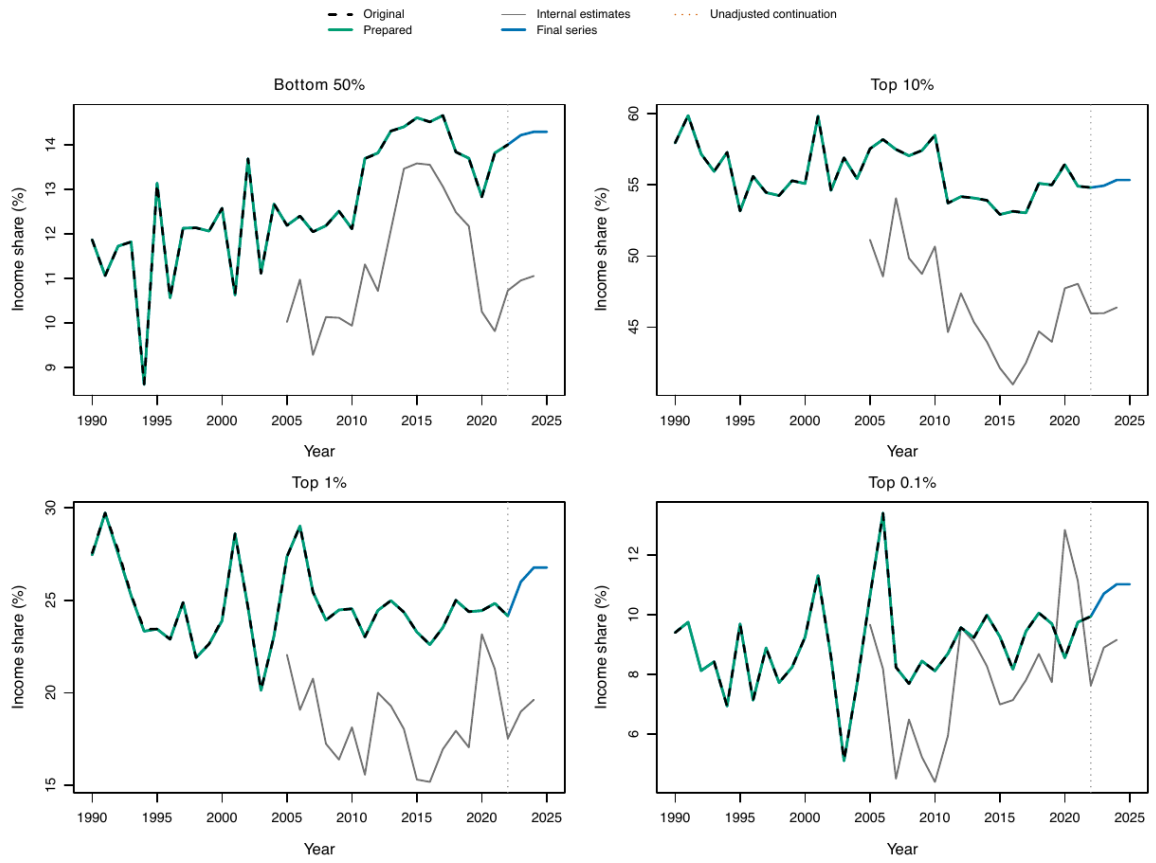
Full exported time coverage. Coincident lines overlap. Latest generation: Current estimate.

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Data sources and coverage

The table below shows the years covered by the main inputs. Available tax data and national accounts need not cover the same years as the surveys. Estimates for other years may rely on interpolation or on information from other years or countries.

Ecuador: supplied history and continuation



Original is the researcher's supplied file; Prepared includes the agreed consistency corrections. Internal estimates are the project's Ecuador calculations. Their changes determine the continuation after 2022. Final series includes the adjustment needed to keep the income groups consistently ordered; Unadjusted continuation shows the projection before that adjustment. The vertical line marks 2022. The 2025 distribution carries forward 2024.

Years covered by the main inputs

Country	Household surveys	Tax information	Detailed national accounts	Supplied research series
Argentina	2000-2014, 2016-2024	2000-2014	-	-
Brazil	2001-2009, 2011-2024	2002, 2006-2009, 2011-2024	2000-2021	On hold; not used
Chile	2000, 2003, 2006, 2009, 2011, 2013, 2015, 2017, 2020, 2022, 2024	2006, 2009, 2011, 2013, 2015, 2017, 2020, 2022, 2024	2003-2024	-
Colombia	2002-2005, 2008-2024	2014-2023	2014-2024	-
Costa Rica	2000-2024	2010-2016	2012-2021	-
Dominican Republic	2000-2024	2012-2019	2007-2016	-
Ecuador	2001, 2003, 2005-2024	2008-2011	2007-2024	1990-2022
Mexico	2000, 2002, 2004, 2006, 2008, 2010, 2012, 2014, 2016, 2018, 2020, 2022, 2024	2010, 2012, 2014	2003-2024	-
Peru	2000-2024	2016-2020	2007-2024	-
El Salvador	2000-2007, 2009-2010, 2012-2024	2001-2007, 2009-2010, 2012-2017	-	-
Uruguay	2000-2005, 2007-2024	2009-2016	2012, 2016-2022	-

A dash means no input is recorded in this source review. It does not mean that the country has no estimate or that the overall national-income benchmark is unavailable. Listed years may differ across categories within the same source.

Source references

Ecuador, 1990-2022: Nabernegg, M. (2026). Extreme Income Inequality in Ecuador-Dollarization, Commodity Price Boom, and Citizen Revolution.

Common monetary benchmark: World Inequality Database: national-income means used to put all distributions on a common monetary basis.

Brazil, proposed source under review: Morgan and Souza (2026), supplied research series. Full bibliographic reference unconfirmed. Not used in this publication.

The figures and summary tables come from the completed results. Detailed comparison values, source checks and calculation records are retained separately with the research files.

Understanding the estimates

What is being measured?

The figures show how pretax national income is distributed across adults. Income is shared equally between the adults in a couple. A top-1% share of 20%, for example, means that the richest 1% receives one fifth of total income.

Why use tax records as well as surveys?

Household surveys often miss or understate high incomes. Comparisons with tax records are used to estimate a correction. Where a country has no matching tax observation for a particular year, the correction may be inferred from other years of that same country. For Argentina and Costa Rica, a typical pattern across such years is deliberately retained.

When does information from other countries enter?

Some components of national income are unavailable for particular countries. The method estimates these components using relationships observed in other countries with suitable data. This is separate from the within-country survey correction. Fifteen additional country series are estimated from regional distributions rather than independently constructed from local surveys.

Ecuador's supplied series and its continuation

The accepted supplied history ends in 2022. Later changes are estimated for the bottom 50%, middle 40%, next 9% and top 1%, using Ecuador's own calculated changes relative to 2022. The four groups are combined into a consistent distribution. This continuation is the project's calculation, not an additional observation supplied by the researcher.

Brazil's proposed replacement is on hold

The separate Morgan and Souza (2026) series is retained for scientific review and is excluded from publication, including its proposed continuation and its use in regional estimates. The release uses the existing Brazilian survey-and-tax estimates. The full reference and some source definitions remain to be confirmed.

Income shares and monetary income levels

A distribution's shares are first made consistent with total income. Monetary amounts are then scaled to the common World Inequality Database national-income mean. The current benchmark includes 2025 means for the 11 countries with country-specific series. For the 15 regionally estimated countries, 2025 shares are available but missing monetary benchmarks are not filled in. The available metadata do not establish whether the new 2025 benchmark values are observed, estimated or forecast.

Consistency corrections

Small rounding conflicts are resolved without changing the retained group incomes and population weights. For larger conflicts, the distribution is fitted using those retained totals. The bottom-50% and middle-40% summaries are now calculated consistently from the detailed groups; their previous aggregate formulas could give incorrect values. These repairs are not designed to force the new series to match the previous release.

How far do these explanations go?

The comparisons measure differences, but a difference alone does not identify its cause. Where controlled comparisons exist, the country notes report them. Elsewhere the notes identify changed inputs and methods without assigning an unsupported numerical contribution to each. A carried or interpolated year should not be read as independent survey evidence.